Gokarn. The audience for the show, which was telecast live nationally, was entirely middle class comprising both the young and the middle-aged.

As a warm-up for the questions from the audience, Vikram set the conversation rolling by asking me to explain the basic functions of the Reserve Bank, why we were in Chennai and why indeed were we doing a town hall meeting on live TV. Thereafter, we fielded a variety of questions from the audience centred expectedly on soaring prices, low interest rate on savings accounts and fixed deposits, the myriad problems in getting loans from banks, poor customer service, and vexatious KYC (know your customer) requirements. Obviously, we tried our best to respond to all these questions in as simple and direct a language as we could muster.

Midway through the show, I asked for an audience poll on how many thought that the Reserve Bank should be supporting growth even if it risked higher inflation as against those who thought that the Reserve Bank should firmly keep prices under check even if that meant some sacrifice in growth in the short-term. I was aware I was oversimplifying a complex dilemma but I wanted to get the pulse of the public. The votes by show of hands were roughly even for either option. But it struck me immediately, even through only a rough, visible check, that the youngsters in the audience predominantly voted for growth—reflecting, I thought, their concerns for job prospects and career opportunities—while the middle-aged voted for the Reserve Bank giving priority to controlling inflation over all else.

The town hall meetings were a rewarding learning opportunity; they were also big mood elevators. Encouraged by our happy experience with the initial town hall meetings, I started urging senior staff, both in our central office in Mumbai as well as our regional offices spread across the country, to hold focus group meetings in tier-2 cities and district towns with various categories of stakeholders—pensioners, bank depositor associations, microfinance institutions, banking correspondents and small and medium industries. I soon realized that I didn’t need to coax the staff any more; they seemed to have embraced the idea with energy and enthusiasm.